

Lecture Notes for Math 372: Elementary Probability and Statistics

Last updated: September 21, 2026

Probability theory has a right and a left hand. On the right is the rigorous foundational work using the tools of measure theory. The left hand “thinks probabilistically,” reduces problems to gambling situations, coin-tossing, models of a physical particle. – Leo Breiman

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0 Tentative course outline

This course is a problem-oriented introduction to the basic concepts of probability and statistics, providing a foundation for applications and further study.

- **Weeks 1-3:** Introduction to probability theory
 - Experiments, events, sets, probabilities, random variables. Equally likely outcomes, counting techniques. Conditional probability. Independence. Bayes' theorem. (Sections: 2.1-2.5)
- **Weeks 4-5:** Discrete random variables (1.5 weeks)
 - Expected values, mean, variance, binomial distribution, Poisson distribution. Moment generating functions. (Sections: 3.1-3.6)
- **End of week 5: Midterm 1 (Friday, September 25)**
- **Weeks 6-7:** Continuous Random variables (1.5 weeks)
 - Uniform, exponential, gamma, and normal distributions. Intuitive treatment of the Poisson process and development of the relationship with gamma distributions. (Sections: 4.1-4.4)
- **Weeks 8-9:** Multivariate distributions
 - Calculation of probability, covariance, correlation, marginals, conditions. Distributions of sums of random variables and sampling distributions. Central limit theorem. (Sections: 1.1, 1.3, 1.4, 5.1-5.7)
- **End of week 9: Midterm 2 (Tentatively: Friday, October 23)**
- **Week 10:** Introduction to statistical estimation
 - Point and confidence interval estimation. Maximum likelihood, optimal, and unbiased estimators. Examples. (Sections 6.1, 6.2)
- **Weeks 11-12:** Large sample inference
 - Estimation (1.5 weeks): Types and comparison of estimators; sampling distributions for means/proportions, and their use in large sample estimation; sample size. (Sections 7.1, 7.2)
 - Hypothesis testing (1.5 weeks): Components of a test; significance and power; p-values; large-sample tests for means and proportions (Sections: 8.1-8.4)
- **Week 13:** Small sample inference
 - t-distribution, with applications to small sample estimation and testing; χ^2 and F distributions, with applications to inference about variances (Sections: 7.3, 7.4, 8.3)
- **Weeks 14-16:** Regression and χ^2 tests
 - Regression (1.5 weeks): Least squares, correlation coefficient, inference (Sections: 12.1-12.5)
 - χ^2 tests: multinomial distributions, contingency tables, goodness-of-fit (Sections: 14.1-14.3)
- **Last day of instruction: Wednesday, December 9**
- **Final Exam: December 18**

1 2026-08-24 | Week 01 | Lecture 01

- give syllabus
- did the pirates worksheet

2 2026-08-26 | Week 01 | Lecture 02

The nexus question of this lecture: What is a set and what are the basic set operations?

Reading assignment: chapter 2.1

2.1 Set theory

The mathematical formalization of modern probability theory rests on the foundation of set theory.

2.1.1 Definitions and set-builder notation

- A **set** is an unordered collection of distinct objects. The objects of a set are called **elements**. We write the elements of a set inside curly braces, $\{\dots\}$.

Examples: $\{1, 4, 2, 3\}$, $\{\text{cat}, \text{fish}, 5\}$, $\mathbf{Z} := \{\dots, -2, -1, 0, 1, 2, \dots\}$, $\mathbf{R} = \{\text{the real numbers}\}$

- Two sets A and B are **equal**, denoted $A = B$, if they share precisely the same elements. The order that the elements are written is irrelevant.

$$\{1, 2, 3\} = \{3, 1, 2\}.$$

Repeated elements are ignored:

$$\{1, 2, 3\} = \{1, 1, 2, 3\}.$$

- A set is **finite** if it contains a finite number of distinct elements. This number is called the **size** of the set, and is denoted $|A|$.

Example: $|\{\text{cat}, 5\}| = 2$.

- The **empty set** is the set which contains no elements. This is denoted as

$$\emptyset \quad \text{or} \quad \{\}$$

- **Set-builder notation** describes a set by specifying the properties that its elements must satisfy.

Examples:

The set of integers between 1 and 36:

$$\{n \in \mathbb{Z} : 1 \leq n \leq 36\}$$

The set of ordered pairs (x, y) such that x and y are both positive real numbers:

$$\{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : x, y > 0\}$$

The set of even integers:

$$\{n \in \mathbb{Z} : n \text{ is even}\}$$

The set of ordered pairs x, y such that both x and y are integers between 1 and 4:

$$\{(x, y) : x, y \in \{1, 2, 3, 4\}\}$$

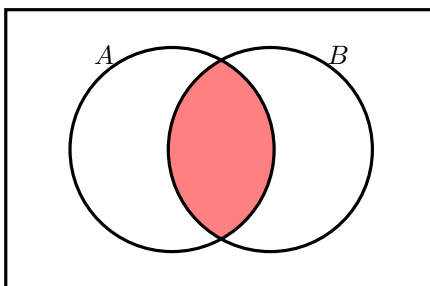
In set builder notation, the colon ‘:’ is read as “such that” and the symbol ‘ $\in$ ’ (which looks like an E) is read as “is an element of”

2.1.2 Set operations

Let A, B be sets.

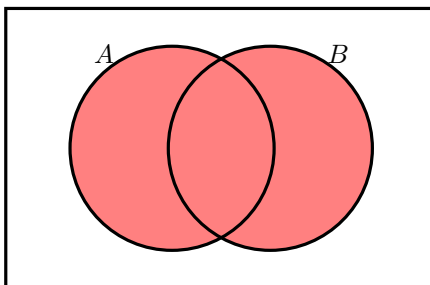
- The **intersection** of A and B , denoted $A \cap B$, is defined by

$$A \cap B = \{x : x \in A \text{ and } x \in B\}.$$



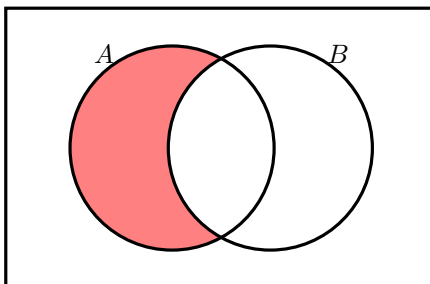
- The **union** of A and B , denoted $A \cup B$, is defined by

$$A \cup B = \{x : x \in A \text{ or } x \in B\}.$$



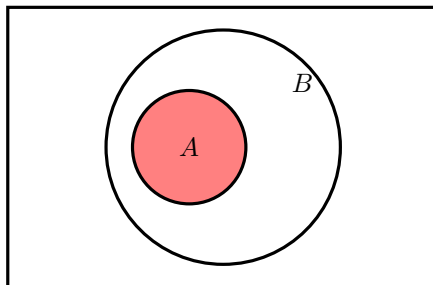
- The **set difference** of A and B , denoted $A \setminus B$, is

$$A \setminus B = \{x : x \in A \text{ and } x \notin B\}.$$



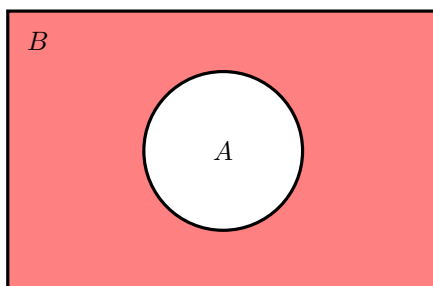
- We say that A is a **subset** of B , and write $A \subseteq B$, if

$$x \in A \implies x \in B.$$

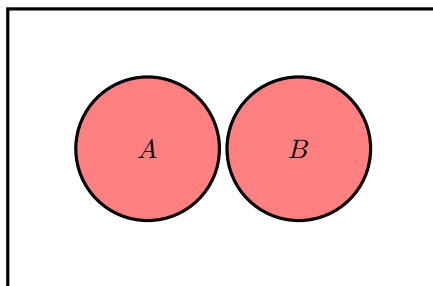


- If $A \subseteq B$, the **complement of A in B** , denoted A^c , is

$$A^c = B \setminus A = \{x : x \in B \text{ and } x \notin A\}.$$



- We say that A and B are **disjoint** if $A \cap B = \emptyset$.



3 2026-08-28 | Week 01 | Lecture 03

The nexus question of this lecture: What does set theory have to do with probability?
Reading assignment: finish chapter 2.1, start 2.2

3.1 A general framework for probability

We begin with a general framework and some terminology to formalize the notions of probability.

- An **experiment** is an activity or process whose outcome is subject to uncertainty, and about which an observation is made.

Examples include flipping a coin, rolling a dice, measuring the size of a wave, or the amount of rainfall, conducting a poll, performing a diagnostic test, opening a pack of Pokemon cards, asking your crush on a date, etc.

- The **sample space** S of an experiment is the set of all possible outcomes. The elements of the sample space are called **sample points**. Each sample point represents a **unique** outcome of the experiment.

Roll a dice. There are six outcomes:

$$1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6$$

These are the sample points. The sample space is

$$S = \{1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6\}.$$

- In probability, we refer to subsets of the sample space as **events**.

an event = a set of outcomes = a subset of S .

We represent events using brackets $[\dots]$, and usually denote them with capital letters.

Examples of events when rolling a dice are:

$$E_1 = [\text{roll a 1}] = \{1\}$$

$$E_2 = [\text{roll a 2}] = \{2\}$$

$$E_3 = [\text{roll a 3}] = \{3\}$$

$$A = [\text{roll an odd number}] = \{1, 3, 5\}$$

$$B = [\text{roll an even number}] = \{2, 4, 6\}$$

$$C = [\text{roll a number less than 5}] = \{1, 2, 3, 4\}$$

$$D = [\text{roll a 2 or a 3}] = \{2, 3\}$$

- The first three events shown are **singleton** sets, containing only one sample point. The book calls these **simple events**. But note

$$1 \neq \{1\}$$

- The empty set $\emptyset$ and the whole sample space S are always both events:

- S is the event that an outcome occurs (“something happens”).
- $\emptyset$ is the event that no outcome occurs. This is called the **null event**.

- Two events are E, F **mutually exclusive** if $E \cap F = \emptyset$ (i.e., the sets E, F are disjoint). This means that the events E and F cannot both happen at the same time.

The events A, B defined above are mutually exclusive, since the dice roll cannot be both even and odd.

- Translating set operations into the language of events,

- $E \cap F$ is the event that both E **and** F occur
- $E \cup F$ is the event that at least one of the events E **or** F occurs
- $E^c = S \setminus E$ is the event that E does **not** occur.

Example 1 (Examples of sample spaces).

- Flip a coin. the sample space is $S = \{T, H\}$
- The amount of rainfall in a day is $S = \{x \in \mathbb{R} : x \geq 0\}$

An example of an event for this sample space is:

$$[\text{between 1 and 2 inches of rain}] = \{x \in \mathbb{R} : 1 \leq x \leq 2\}.$$

- You've got an urn filled with 300,000,000 balls. Exactly one ball is made of gold. Draw a ball out at random. If it's not the gold ball, put it back and keep repeating until you get the gold ball. Once you get the gold ball, you are done. The output of this experiment is *the number of times you drew a ball from the urn*. The sample space is

$$S = \{1, 2, 3, 4, \dots\}.$$

The last two examples show that the sample space need not be finite.

End of Example 1. $\square$

3.2 Random variable

We often associate numbers with outcomes of an experiment.

Definition 2 (Random variables). Let S be a sample space of an experiment. A **random variable** is any rule that associates a number with each outcome in the S . Formally, it is a function whose domain is S and whose range is $\mathbb{R}$.

Most interesting events are defined using random variables.

Example 3 (sum 2d4). Roll a 4-sided dice twice (this is the **experiment**). There are 16 possible **outcomes**. The **sample space** is

$$S = \{(x, y) : x, y \in \{1, 2, 3, 4\}\},$$

which consists of 16 ordered pairs (x, y) , the **sample points**. We can enumerate the sample space as a table:

		Dice 2			
		1	2	3	4
Dice 1	1	(1, 1)	(1, 2)	(1, 3)	(1, 4)
	2	(2, 1)	(2, 2)	(2, 3)	(2, 4)
	3	(3, 1)	(3, 2)	(3, 3)	(3, 4)
	4	(4, 1)	(4, 2)	(3, 4)	(4, 4)

Let X be the sum of the two rolls. This is an example of a **random variable**. We can represent X by the following table:

		Dice 2			
		1	2	3	4
Dice 1	1	2	3	4	5
	2	3	4	5	6
	3	4	5	6	7
	4	5	6	7	8

We can define events using X . For example

$$\begin{aligned} [X \leq 3] &= \{(x, y) \in S : x + y \leq 3\} = \{(1, 1), (1, 2), (2, 1)\} \\ [X = 4] &= \{(x, y) \in S : x + y = 4\} = \{(1, 3), (2, 2), (3, 1)\} \\ [X \leq 4] &= [X \leq 3] \cup [X = 4] = \{(1, 1), (1, 2), (2, 1), (1, 3), (2, 2), (3, 1)\} \\ [X \text{ is even}] &= \{(1, 1), (1, 3), (2, 2), (2, 4), (3, 1), (3, 3), (4, 2), (4, 4)\}. \\ &\text{etc.} \end{aligned}$$

End of Example 3. $\square$

3.3 The enumeration principle

On Monday's worksheet, I had you do a bunch of problems where you computed probabilities by counting outcomes. This is a simple but critically important idea, called the **enumeration principle**.

Enumeration principle: If the sample space is finite and consists of *equally likely outcomes*, then we can compute lots of probabilities easily by listing outcomes and counting them. To be precise, for any event A ,

$$\mathbb{P}[A] = \frac{|A|}{|S|} = \frac{\# \text{ of outcomes in } A}{\# \text{ of outcomes in } S}.$$

So using X from Example 44,

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}[X = 4] &= \frac{3}{16} \\ \mathbb{P}[X \text{ is even}] &= \frac{8}{16} = \frac{1}{2}. \end{aligned}$$

4 2026-08-31 | Week 02 | Lecture 04

The nexus question of this lecture: What is probability?
Reading assignment: finish chapter 2.2, start 2.3

4.1 Recap and coin flipping example

Recall: The **sample space** of an experiment is the *set* of all possible **outcomes**. An **event** is a collection of outcomes. That is,

an event = a set of outcomes = a subset of the sample space S .

Example 4 (Repeated coin flipping). Consider an experiment in which we flip a coin repeatedly until we get a heads. The output of this experiment is *the number of times we flipped the coin*. There is no upper bound on how many times we might have to flip the coin, so the sample space is

$$S = \{1, 2, 3, 4, \dots\}.$$

Let $X =$ (number of coin flips). Then

$$\mathbb{P}[X = 1] = \mathbb{P}[1^{\text{st}} \text{ flip heads}] = \frac{1}{2}$$

and

$$\mathbb{P}[X = 2] = \mathbb{P}[1^{\text{st}} \text{ flip tails, } 2^{\text{nd}} \text{ flip heads}] = \frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{2} = \frac{1}{4}.$$

Similarly,

$$\mathbb{P}[X = n] = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^n, \quad n \in \{1, 2, \dots\}. \quad (1)$$

End of Example 4. $\square$

We will need one more definition.

Definition 5 (Pairwise disjoint). A sequence of events $(A_1, A_2, \dots)$ is **pairwise disjoint** if

$$A_i \cap A_j = \emptyset \quad \text{whenever } i \neq j.$$

In other words, no two events have any “overlap”. Equivalently, no two events can simultaneously occur.

4.2 What is probability? The three axioms

We denote the probability of an event E by $\mathbb{P}[E]$ or $\mathbb{P}(E)$. But what is “probability”? And what is $\mathbb{P}$?

Definition 6 (Probability Axioms). Let S be a sample space associated with an experiment. A function $\mathbb{P}$ is called a **probability function** on S if it satisfies the following three axioms:

A.1 (Nonnegativity) $\mathbb{P}[E] \geq 0$ for every event $E \subseteq S$.

A.2 (Sum-to-one) $\mathbb{P}[S] = 1$.

A.3 (Countable additivity) If $A_1, A_2, \dots$ is an infinite sequence of pairwise disjoint events then

$$\mathbb{P}[A_1 \cup A_2 \cup \dots] = \mathbb{P}[A_1] + \mathbb{P}[A_2] + \dots.$$

If $\mathbb{P}$ is a probability function, then for every event $E \subseteq S$, the number $\mathbb{P}[E]$ is called the **probability** of E .

The above definition may feel unsatisfying because it only tells us the conditions that probabilities must satisfy; it doesn't tell us how to assign specific probabilities to events. But before judging this definition, we should first explore the implications of these axioms.

The first two axioms, **A.1** and **A.2** are self-evident. The last one, **A.3**, is more technical and harder to decipher. The next example gives an application of axiom **A.3**.

Example 7 (Continuation of Example 4). What is the probability that we flip the coin an even number of times? That is, what is $\mathbb{P}[X \text{ is even}]$?

Define

$$E_n := [X = n], \quad n \in \{1, 2, \dots\}$$

Then

$$[X \text{ is even}] = E_2 \cup E_4 \cup E_6 \cup E_8 \cup \dots$$

The sequence $E_2, E_4, E_6 \dots$ is pairwise disjoint. Therefore

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}[X \text{ is even}] &= \mathbb{P}[E_2 \cup E_4 \cup E_6 \cup E_8 \cup \dots] \\ &= \mathbb{P}[E_2] + \mathbb{P}[E_4] + \mathbb{P}[E_6] + \mathbb{P}[E_8] + \dots \quad (\text{by } \mathbf{A.3}) \\ &= \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^4 + \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^6 + \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^8 + \dots \quad (\text{by Eq. (1)}) \\ &= \frac{1}{4} + \left(\frac{1}{4}\right)^2 + \left(\frac{1}{4}\right)^3 + \left(\frac{1}{4}\right)^4 + \dots \\ &= \frac{\frac{1}{4}}{1 - \frac{1}{4}} \quad \text{by geometric series formula } \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} r^n = \frac{r}{1-r} \\ &= \frac{1}{3}. \end{aligned}$$

So the probability that you flip the coin an *even* number of times is only $1/3$.

End of Example 7. $\square$

4.3 Basic properties of probability functions

The next theorem enumerates some basic properties that can be derived using only the three axioms.

Proposition 8 (Basic properties of probabilities).

- (i.) (The probability of no outcome occurring is zero) $\mathbb{P}[\emptyset] = 0$.
- (ii.) (Finite additivity) If $E_1, \dots, E_n$ are pairwise disjoint, then
$$\mathbb{P}[E_1 \cup E_2 \cup \dots \cup E_n] = \mathbb{P}[E_1] + \mathbb{P}[E_2] + \dots + \mathbb{P}[E_n].$$
- (iii.) ("With probability one, an event E either does occur or doesn't") $\mathbb{P}[E^c] = 1 - \mathbb{P}[E]$.
- (iv.) (Excision Property) If A, B are events and $A \subseteq B$, then

$$\mathbb{P}[B \setminus A] = \mathbb{P}[B] - \mathbb{P}[A].$$

"The probability that you get hit by a non-red car is the probability that you get hit by a car minus the probability that you get hit by a red car."

- (v.) ("The particular is less likely than the general") If A, B are events and $A \subseteq B$, then $\mathbb{P}[A] \leq \mathbb{P}[B]$

"The probability that you get hit by a car is higher than the probability that you get hit by a red car."
- (vi.) ("Probabilities are between 0 and 1") For any event E , $0 \leq \mathbb{P}[E] \leq 1$.

Proof of Proposition 8.

- First we will prove (i.). Let $E_i = \emptyset$ for all $i = 1, 2, 3, \dots$. Then $(E_i)_{i=1}^\infty$ is a pairwise disjoint sequence, and $E_1 \cup E_2 \cup \dots = \emptyset$. Therefore,

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}[\emptyset] &= \mathbb{P}[E_1 \cup E_2 \cup \dots] \\ &= \mathbb{P}[E_1] + \mathbb{P}[E_2] + \dots \\ &= \mathbb{P}[\emptyset] + \mathbb{P}[\emptyset] + \dots\end{aligned}\quad \text{by A.3}$$

The equation $\mathbb{P}[\emptyset] = (\mathbb{P}[\emptyset] + \mathbb{P}[\emptyset] + \dots)$ forces $\mathbb{P}[\emptyset] = 0$. This proves (i.).

- Next we prove (ii.). Let $E_1, \dots, E_n$ be a finite sequence of events which are pairwise disjoint. Then expand the sequence by taking $E_i = \emptyset$ for every positive integer i greater than n . Then

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}\left[\bigcup_{i=1}^n E_i\right] &= \mathbb{P}\left[\bigcup_{i=1}^\infty E_i\right] \\ &= \sum_{i=1}^\infty \mathbb{P}[E_i] \\ &= \mathbb{P}[E_1] + \dots + \mathbb{P}[E_n] + \underbrace{\mathbb{P}[\emptyset] + \mathbb{P}[\emptyset] + \dots}_{=0 \text{ by (i.)}} \\ &= \mathbb{P}[E_1] + \dots + \mathbb{P}[E_n].\end{aligned}\quad \text{by A.3}$$

This proves (ii.).

- Next we prove (iii.). Let E be any event. Then

$$\begin{aligned}1 &= \mathbb{P}[S] && \text{by A.2} \\ &= \mathbb{P}[E \cup E^c] && \text{since } S = E \cup E^c \\ &= \mathbb{P}[E] + \mathbb{P}[E^c] && \text{by (ii.), since } E \cap E^c = \emptyset.\end{aligned}$$

This proves (iii.).

- Next we prove (iv.). Since $A \subseteq B$,

$$B = A \cup (B \cap A^c).$$

This is a disjoint union. Therefore by (ii.),

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}[B] &= \mathbb{P}[A] + \mathbb{P}[B \cap A^c] \\ &= \mathbb{P}[A] + \mathbb{P}[B \setminus A].\end{aligned}$$

Rearranging terms proves (iv.).

- Next we prove (v.). Assume $A \subseteq B$. Then by (iv.),

$$\mathbb{P}[B \setminus A] = \mathbb{P}[B] - \mathbb{P}[A].$$

Moreover, by A.1, $\mathbb{P}[B \setminus A] \geq 0$. Hence

$$0 \leq \mathbb{P}[B] - \mathbb{P}[A]$$

and this implies (v.).

- Finally, we will show (vi.). Let E be an event. Then

$$\begin{aligned}0 &\leq \mathbb{P}[E] && \text{by A.1} \\ &\leq \mathbb{P}[S] && \text{by (v.), since } E \subseteq S \\ &= 1 && \text{by A.2.}\end{aligned}$$

□

5 2026-09-02 | Week 02 | Lecture 05

The topic for this lecture: Combinatorial principles
Reading assignment: chapter 2.3

There are three main counting principles we'll look at:

- multiplication principle
- permutation principle
- combination principle

5.1 The multiplication principle

Notation 9. Denote the set consisting of the first n positive integers by

$$[n] = \{1, \dots, n\}.$$

Definition 10 (Tuple). Let k be a positive integer. A **k -tuple** is an ordered list

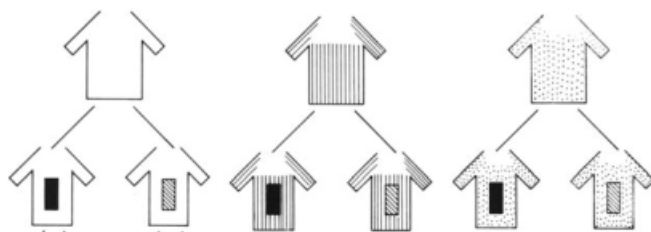
$$(a_1, a_2, \dots, a_k)$$

of k objects. We call a_i the i^{th} **coordinate** of the tuple.

Remark 11. The word *ordered* is key. $(1, 2)$ and $(2, 1)$ are different 2-tuples, and $(1, 1, 2)$ is a perfectly fine 3-tuple even though it repeats an entry.

Theorem 12 (The multiplication principle). *Suppose an object is built by making k choices in order, where the number of options for the 1st choice is n_1 , the number of options for the 2nd is n_2 , and so forth. Then the number of objects that can be built is $n_1 n_2 \cdots n_k$.*

Example 13. A man has 3 shirts and 2 ties. How many ways can he dress himself?



We can schematize this as three shirts s_1, s_2, s_3 and two ties t_1, t_2 , in which case the possible outfits are:

$$\begin{aligned} &(s_1, t_1) \ (s_2, t_1) \ (s_3, t_1) \\ &(s_1, t_2) \ (s_2, t_2) \ (s_3, t_2) \end{aligned}$$

Of course, we don't need to write s and t ; it is enough to write

$$\begin{aligned} &(1, 1) \ (2, 1) \ (3, 1) \\ &(1, 2) \ (2, 2) \ (3, 2) \end{aligned}$$

where the first slot is “shirt” and the second is “tie”. Equivalently,

$$\{(a_1, a_2) : a_1 \in [3], a_2 \in [2]\}.$$

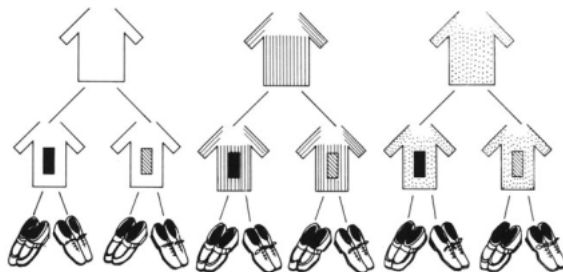
The total number of outfits is $3 \times 2 = 6$.

If the man also has 2 pairs of shoes, we can add a third slot for “shoes”, so the question is asking to count the number of elements in the set

$$\{(a_1, a_2, a_3) : a_1 \in [3], a_2 \in [2], a_3 \in [2]\}$$

By Theorem 12, the number of elements in this set is $3 \times 2 \times 2 = 12$. Thus the number of ways he can dress himself 12.

This is shown in the following tree diagram:



End of Example 13. $\square$

Corollary 14. $|\{(a_1, a_2, \dots, a_k) : a_1 \in [n_1], a_2 \in [n_2], \dots, a_k \in [n_k]\}| = n_1 n_2 \cdots n_k$.

Proof. Follows immediately by Theorem 12 $\square$

5.2 Permutations

Example 15. Suppose I have a set of 6 objects:

$$\{\text{coin, card, pen, clip, craine, dice}\}$$

Question 1. How many ways can I order these six objects?

Answer: $6! = 6 \times 5 \times 4 \times 3 \times 2 \times 1$.

Question 2. How many ways can I arrange just four elements of S ?

Answer: $6! = 6 \times 5 \times 4 \times 3$.

End of Example 15. $\square$

In the remainder, we will formalize these ideas.

Definition 16 (Permutation). Given a set S , a **permutation** of S is an ordering of all the elements of S .

Proposition 17 (Counting permutations). *The total number of ways to order n distinct objects is*

$$n! = n \times (n-1) \times (n-2) \times \cdots \times 2 \times 1.$$

(Note that $0! = 1$.)

Definition 18 (Permutation of size k). Given a set S , a **permutation of size k** is an ordered subset of S containing exactly k elements.

Theorem 19 (The permutation principle). *Let $P_{k,n}$ be the number of permutations of size k that can be formed from a set of n objects. Then*

$$P_{k,n} = n \cdot (n-1) \cdot (n-2) \cdots (n-k+1) = \frac{n!}{(n-k)!}$$

(Note: the right-hand side is a product of k terms.)

Proof. Build the list one entry at a time. There are n choices for the first entry, then $n-1$ for the second (since one element was used up). Then $n-2$, and so on, with $n-k+1$ choices for the k^{th} entry. By Theorem 12, the number of choices multiply, giving the formula. $\square$

5.3 Combinations

Definition 20 (Combination of size k). Given a set S , a **combination of size k** is a subset of S containing exactly k elements.

Theorem 21 (The combination principle). *Let S be a set with n elements. The number of combinations of size k is*

$$\binom{n}{k} = \frac{n!}{k!(n-k)!}$$

Proof. Let $C_{k,n}$ be the number of subsets of S of size k . Observe that for every unordered subset of size k , there are $k!$ ways to order it by Proposition 17. Hence,

$$k! \times (\text{number of unordered subsets of size } k) = (\text{number of ordered subsets of size } k).$$

Changing notation,

$$k! C_{k,n} = P_{k,n}.$$

Therefore

$$C_{k,n} = \frac{P_{k,n}}{k!}$$

By the formula from Theorem 19,

$$C_{k,n} = \frac{n!}{(n-k)! k!}$$

□

6 2026-09-04 | Week 02 | Lecture 06

6.1 Examples of counting principles

Example 22. A dessert company has 32 distinct desserts on its menu: 6 types of pie, 9 types of cake, and 17 flavors of ice cream.

- (a) **Question:** After purchasing 4 different desserts, a customer decides he will eat them all in a row, and he cares about the order in which he eats them. How many different ways can he eat his 4 desserts?

Solution: Here we are counting the number of ways to order set of four objects. This number is $4!$ by Proposition 17.

- (b) **Question:** How many ways are there for the customer to choose four desserts and then eat them in a particular order of his choice?

Solution 1: By the combination principle, there are $\binom{32}{4}$ combinations of desserts that the customer could choose. Moreover, by part (a), for each combination of 4 desserts, he can order them $4!$ ways. Therefore by the multiplication principle, there are

$$\binom{32}{4} \times 4! = 32 \cdot 31 \cdot 30 \cdot 29$$

ways that the customer could choose and then eat four desserts.

Solution 2: Another solution would be to note that we want to count the number of permutations of size $k = 4$ from a set of $n = 32$ distinct objects. By the permutation principle, this number is

$$P_{4,32} = 32 \cdot 31 \cdot 30 \cdot 29.$$

- (c) **Question:** If 9 desserts are randomly selected, how many ways are there to obtain 3 deserts of each type (pie, cake, and ice cream)?

Solution: For pie, there are $\binom{6}{3}$ combinations possible. For cake, there are $\binom{9}{3}$ combinations possible, and for ice cream, there are $\binom{17}{3}$.

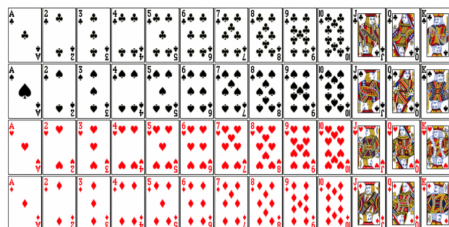
By the multiplication principle, there are

$$\binom{6}{3} \times \binom{9}{3} \times \binom{17}{3}$$

ways to simultaneously select 3 pies, 3 cakes, and 3 ice cream flavors.

End of Example 22. $\square$

Example 23 (Poker). A poker hand consist of 5 randomly chosen cards from a standard 52-card deck.



- (a) **Question:** How many distinct poker hands are there?

Solution:

$$\binom{52}{5} = \frac{52!}{5! \cdot 47!} = 2,598,960$$

- (b) **Question:** A **flush** occurs when all five cards are the same suit. How many ways are there to get a flush?

Solution:

$$4 \times \binom{13}{5} = 4 \cdot \frac{13!}{5!8!} = 4 \cdot \frac{13 \cdot 12 \cdot 11 \cdot 10 \cdot 9}{5 \cdot 4 \cdot 3 \cdot 2 \cdot 1} = 5148$$

The 4 is to choose a suit. Then we choose 5 out of 13 cards in that suit.

- (c) **Question:** What's the probability of getting a flush?

Solution: To answer this, we use the enumeration principle:

$$\frac{\binom{4}{1} \times \binom{13}{5}}{\binom{52}{5}} = \frac{5,148}{2,598,960} \approx 0.002$$

In other words, the probability of a flush is pretty low: about 0.2%.

End of Example 23. $\square$

7 2026-09-09 | Week 03 | Lecture 07

The topic for this lecture: Conditional probability
Reading assignment: Chapter 2.4

7.1 Introduction to craps

Craps is a dice-rolling game in which a player, known as the shooter, rolls a pair of 6-sided dice. The shooter wins, loses or re-rolls depending on what happens.

Here's a set of rules for the shooter:

1. You roll two dice and add them up.
 - If the sum is 2, 3, or 12, you lose ("craps")
 - If you roll 7 or 11, then you win ("natural")
 - Otherwise you establish "point", which is whatever number you got.
2. If you established point, then you must keep rolling until one of two events occurs:
 - You roll a 7: you lose
 - You roll your "point" number: you win.

Tallying the results from the in-class activity, we saw that shooters won about 56% of the time. Is this a fair game? Does the shooter have an advantage? We will set out to answer this question. To do so, we'll need to introduce some new ideas. A key idea is that of conditional probability:

7.2 Conditional probability

This section is based on section 2.4 in the text.

Definition 24 (Conditional probability). Let A, B be events, and assume that $\mathbb{P}[A] > 0$. Then the **conditional probability of B , given A** , denoted $\mathbb{P}[B | A]$, is given by the formula

$$\mathbb{P}[B | A] = \frac{\mathbb{P}[A \cap B]}{\mathbb{P}[A]}.$$

Interpretation: $\mathbb{P}[B | A]$ is the probability of B when we know that event A happened.

Multiplication rule: $\mathbb{P}[A \cap B] = \mathbb{P}[B | A] \mathbb{P}[A]$

Definition 25. We say that there exists a **positive relationship** between events A and B if

$$\mathbb{P}[B | A] > \mathbb{P}[B],$$

and a **negative relationship** if

$$\mathbb{P}[B | A] < \mathbb{P}[B].$$

- Smoking and getting lung cancer have a positive relationship: if you know someone is a smoker (A), then the probability that they get lung cancer (B) is higher than if you didn't know they were a smoker.

Example 26 (Conditional probability). I roll a dice behind a screen. I tell you that I rolled an even number. What's the probability that the dice roll is a 4 or a 6?

Solution: We have $S = \{1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6\}$, $A = \{2, 4, 6\}$, $B = \{4, 6\}$. We want to compute $\mathbb{P}[B | A]$. By Definition 24,

$$\mathbb{P}[B | A] = \frac{\mathbb{P}[AB]}{\mathbb{P}[A]} = \frac{2/6}{1/2} = \frac{2}{3}.$$

Put differently, we have three outcomes in A , which are all equally likely. Two of them (4 and 6) mean that event B occurs. So by the enumeration principle, the probability is $2/3$.

End of Example 26. $\square$

Example 27 (Conditional Probability). I roll two dice and add them up. Call this number X . Then $\mathbb{P}[X = 7] = \frac{1}{6}$, which we can see by counting up the possibilities. Now, what about if I tell you that I rolled the dice and got a sum greater than 4? Now that you have a little additional information, you can exclude the possibilities that $X = 1, 2, 3$ or $X = 4$. So with this new information, you should evaluate the probability that $X = 7$ as greater than before. That is, now we want

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}[X = 7|X > 4] &= \frac{\mathbb{P}[X = 7 \text{ and } X > 4]}{\mathbb{P}[X > 4]} \\ &= \frac{\mathbb{P}[X = 7]}{\mathbb{P}[X > 4]} \\ &= \frac{1/6}{30/36} \\ &= \frac{1}{5}.\end{aligned}$$

This answer makes sense because $\frac{1}{5} > \frac{1}{6}$, consistent with our intuition.

End of Example 27. $\square$

8 2026-09-11 | Week 03 | Lecture 08

The topic for this lecture: Conditional probability
Reading assignment: Chapter 2.4

8.1 Conditional probability examples

Example 28 (Urn - example of multiplication rule). An urn contains 6 white balls and 9 black balls. If 4 balls are drawn at random, what is the probability that the first 2 are white and the last 2 are black?

Solution: Let A be the event that the first two balls are white, and B the event that the last two balls are black. Then the desired probability is

$$\mathbb{P}[A \cap B] = \mathbb{P}[B | A] \mathbb{P}[A] \quad (2)$$

Now,

$$\mathbb{P}[A] = \frac{\binom{6}{2}}{\binom{15}{2}} = \frac{1}{7}.$$

Moreover, given that A occurs, then 4 white balls and 9 black balls remain. So

$$\mathbb{P}[B | A] = \frac{\binom{9}{2}}{\binom{13}{2}} = \frac{6}{13}.$$

Therefore by Eq. (2),

$$\mathbb{P}[A \cap B] = \frac{1}{7} \cdot \frac{6}{13} = \frac{6}{91} \approx 0.07$$

End of Example 28. $\square$

Example 29 (Similar to examples 2.27 and 2.28 in the textbook). A vampire goes to the blood bank looking to find some type O+ blood (the most delicious type). He finds 4 unlabeled bags of blood. Only one of the bags is O+, but the vampire doesn't know which one, so he resorts to taste-testing to find the O+ bag.

- (a) What is the probability that he must test at least 3 bags to find the desired type?

Solution: Let X be the number of tested bags. We want to find $\mathbb{P}[X \geq 3]$. Let

$$A = [\text{first bag isn't O+}] \quad \text{and} \quad B = [\text{second bag isn't O+}]$$

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}[X \geq 3] &= \mathbb{P}[A \cap B] \\ &= \mathbb{P}[A] \mathbb{P}[B | A] \\ &= \frac{3}{4} \cdot \frac{2}{3} = \frac{1}{2}. \end{aligned}$$

- (b) What's the probability that he must test exactly 3 bags?

Solution: We want $\mathbb{P}[X = 3] = \mathbb{P}[\text{first bag isn't O+} \cap \text{second bag isn't O+} \cap \text{third bag is O+}]$.

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}[X = 3] &= \mathbb{P}[\text{third is O+} | \text{first isn't O+} \cap \text{second isn't O+}] \times \mathbb{P}[\text{second isn't O+} | \text{first isn't O+}] \cdot \mathbb{P}[\text{first isn't O+}] \\ &= \frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{2}{3} \cdot \frac{3}{4} = \frac{1}{4} \end{aligned}$$

Here we have used the following multiplication rule:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}[A \cap B \cap C] &= \mathbb{P}[C | A \cap B] \mathbb{P}[A \cap B] \\ &= \mathbb{P}[C | A \cap B] \mathbb{P}[B | A] \mathbb{P}[A] \end{aligned}$$

with $A = [\text{first bag isn't O+}]$, $B = [\text{second bag isn't O+}]$, and $C = [\text{third bag is O+}]$.

End of Example 29. $\square$

Example 30. Suppose two cards are drawn at random from a standard 52 card playing deck. Let

$A =$ [at least one ace was drawn]

$B =$ [both cards drawn are aces]

$C =$ [the ace of clubs was drawn]

Are $\mathbb{P}(B \mid A)$ and $\mathbb{P}(B \mid C)$ the same?

End of Example 30. $\square$

9 2026-09-14 | Week 04 | Lecture 09

The topic for this lecture: The Law of Total Probability
Reading assignment: Chapter 2.4, start chapter 2.5

9.1 The law of total probability

Definition 31. Let S be the sample space of some experiment, and let $A_1, \dots, A_n \subseteq S$ be events. We say that $A_1, \dots, A_n$ **partition** S if

- (i) $A_1 \cup A_2 \cup \dots \cup A_n = S$; and
- (ii) $A_i \cap A_j = \emptyset$ whenever $i \neq j$.

Remark 32. Condition (i) says that at least one of the events $A_1, \dots, A_n$ occurs. Condition (ii) says that at most one of them occurs.

Theorem 33 (Law of Total Probability). *Let $A_1, \dots, A_n$ be events which partition their sample space. Then for any event B ,*

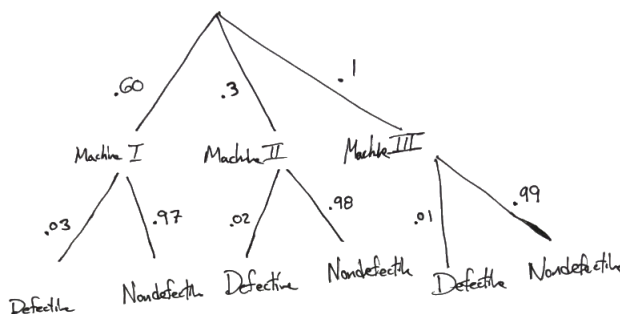
$$\mathbb{P}[B] = \sum_{k=1}^n \mathbb{P}[B | A_k] \mathbb{P}[A_k]$$

Example 34. A munitions factory produces 155mm artillery rounds using three machines: 60% of rounds are produced by machine I, 30% by machine II, and 10% by machine III. Engineers discover that

- 3% of rounds produced by machine I are defective
- 2% of rounds produced by machine II are defective
- 1% of rounds produced by machine III are defective.

Given a defective round, what is the probability that it was produced by machine III?

Solution: Let's make a diagram to illustrate this:



Let

$D = [\text{shell is defective}]$

$M_1 = [\text{shell was made by machine I}]$

$M_2 = [\text{shell was made by machine II}]$

$M_3 = [\text{shell was made by machine III}].$

We want to find $\mathbb{P}[M_3 | D] = \mathbb{P}[\text{machine III} | \text{defective}]$.

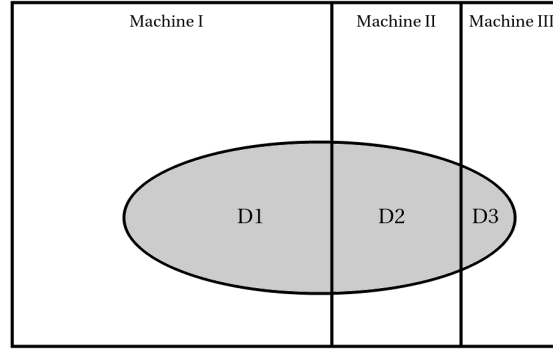
$$\mathbb{P}[M_3 | D] = \frac{\mathbb{P}[M_3 \cap D]}{\mathbb{P}[D]} \tag{3}$$

Now we compute the numerator and denominator separately:

By the multiplication rule,

$$\mathbb{P}[M_3 \cap D] = \mathbb{P}[D \mid M_3] \mathbb{P}[M_3] = (.01)(.1) = .001.$$

Next, we compute the denominator. The following figure illustrates the sample space, which consists of shells produces by machines I, II and III. The grey region represents the event that the randomly selected shell is defective.



$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}[D] &= \mathbb{P}[D1] + \mathbb{P}[D2] + \mathbb{P}[D3] \\ &= \mathbb{P}[D \cap M_1] + \mathbb{P}[D \cap M_2] + \mathbb{P}[D \cap M_3] \\ &= \mathbb{P}[D \mid M_1] \mathbb{P}[M_1] + \mathbb{P}[D \mid M_2] \mathbb{P}[M_2] + \mathbb{P}[D \mid M_3] \mathbb{P}[M_3] \\ &= (.03)(.6) + (.02)(.3) + (.01)(.1) \\ &= .025 \end{aligned}$$

Hence by Eq. (3),

$$\mathbb{P}[M_3 \mid D] = \frac{.001}{.025} = .04.$$

In other words, 4% of defective rounds are produced by machine III.

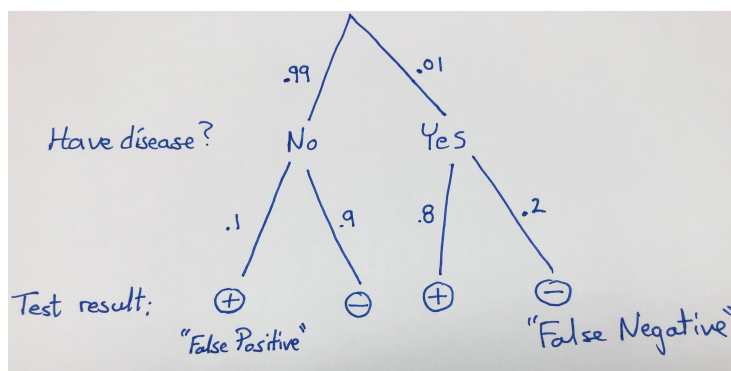
End of Example 34. $\square$

10 2026-09-16 | Week 04 | Lecture 10

The topic for this lecture: diagnostic tests and independence
Reading assignment: Chapter 2.4, 2.5

10.1 Conditional probability example: diagnostic tests

Example 35 (Diagnostic tests). Prevalance of a disease in a population is 1%. A new diagnostic test is advertised as having a false positive rate of .1 and a false negative rate of .2. (In other words, 10% of positive tests are wrong, and 20% of negative tests are wrong.) Suppose you are selected for a random screening, and you test positive. What's the chance that you have the disease?



We want $\mathbb{P}[\text{have disease} \mid \text{test positive}]$. For brevity, let's let

$$D = [\text{have disease}] \quad \text{and} \quad T^+ = [\text{test positive}].$$

In other words, we want

$$\mathbb{P}[D \mid T^+]$$

By the definition of conditional probability,

$$\mathbb{P}[D \mid T^+] = \frac{\mathbb{P}[T^+ \cap D]}{\mathbb{P}[T^+]} \quad (4)$$

We will compute the numerator and denominator separately:

- (Numerator) By the multiplication rule for conditional probability ($\mathbb{P}[A \cap B] = \mathbb{P}[A|B] \mathbb{P}[B]$), we have

$$\mathbb{P}[T^+ \cap D] = \mathbb{P}[T^+ \mid D] \mathbb{P}[D] = (.8)(.01) = 0.008.$$

We've now computed the numerator of Eq. (4).

- (Denominator) By the law of total probability,

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}[T^+] &= \underbrace{\mathbb{P}[T^+ \mid D] \mathbb{P}[D]}_{=0.008 \text{ by ??}} + \underbrace{\mathbb{P}[T^+ \mid D^c] \mathbb{P}[D^c]}_{=(.1)(.99)=0.099} \\ &= (.8)(.01) + (.1)(.99) \\ &= 0.008 + 0.099 \end{aligned}$$

Finally, having done the necessary work, we can now plug our results into Eq. (4):

$$\mathbb{P}[D \mid T^+] = \frac{0.008}{0.008 + 0.099} \approx .075$$

We conclude that if you test positive in a random screening, your probability of actually having the disease is about 7.5%. *This result is perhaps suprising: even though you tested positive, you still probably don't have the disease.*

End of Example 35. $\square$

10.2 Independence

This is based on section 2.5 in the textbook.

Previously, we saw that A and B have a **positive relationship** if

$$\mathbb{P}[B | A] > \mathbb{P}[B]$$

and a **negative relationship** if

$$\mathbb{P}[B | A] < \mathbb{P}[B]$$

What about when $\mathbb{P}[B | A] = \mathbb{P}[B]$?

Definition 36 (Independence). Events A, B are **independent** if

$$\mathbb{P}[A \cap B] = \mathbb{P}[A] \mathbb{P}[B].$$

Otherwise, the events are said to be **dependent**.

This definition generalizes in the natural way:

Definition 37 (Mutual independence). Events $A_1, \dots, A_n$ are **independent** if

$$\mathbb{P}[A_1 \cap A_2 \cap \dots \cap A_n] = \mathbb{P}[A_1] \mathbb{P}[A_2] \dots \mathbb{P}[A_n].$$

Proposition 38. If A, B are events with positive probabilities then the following are equivalent:

- (i.) A and B are independent.
- (ii.) $\mathbb{P}[A | B] = \mathbb{P}[A]$ and $\mathbb{P}[B | A] = \mathbb{P}[B]$

Remark 39. (ii.) says that A and B have neither a positive nor negative relationship. In words, independence means that the probabilities of each event are unaffected by whether or not the other event occurs. Proposition 38 simply formalizes this idea using conditional probabilities.

Remark 40. A common mistake is to mix up “independence” with “mutually exclusive”. Mutually exclusive events are typically **not** independent. That’s because if you know that one happened, then you know that the other didn’t. That’s about as far from independence as you can get!

10.3 Examples of using independence

Example 41. The proportions of blood types in the US are

$$A: 40\% \quad B: 11\% \quad AB: 4\% \quad O: 45\%$$

- (a) What is the probability that two randomly-selected people are both O .

Solution: Assuming that the two blood types are independent, we have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}[\text{person 1 has O blood} \cap \text{person 2 has O blood}] &= \mathbb{P}[\text{person 1 has O blood}] \mathbb{P}[\text{person 2 has O blood}] \\ &= (.45)(.45) \\ &= 0.2025. \end{aligned}$$

- (b) What is the probability that two randomly-selected people have matching blood types?

Solution: Let M be the event that the people have matching blood type, and let M_X be the event that both people have type X blood, for $X \in \{A, B, AB, O\}$.

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}[M] &= \mathbb{P}[M_A \cup M_B \cup M_{AB} \cup M_O] \\ &= \mathbb{P}[M_A] + \mathbb{P}[M_B] + \mathbb{P}[M_{AB}] + \mathbb{P}[M_O], \end{aligned}$$

where the last equality followed from the fact that the events M_A, M_B, M_{AB}, M_O are pairwise disjoint.

We already computed $\mathbb{P}[M_O] = (.45)(.45) = .2025$. By similar calculations, we get

$$\mathbb{P}[M] = (.40)(.40) + (.11)(.11) + (.04)(.04) + (.45)(.45) = .3762.$$

End of Example 41. $\square$

11 2026-09-18 | Week 04 | Lecture 11

The topic for this lecture: random variables
Reading assignment: Chapter 3.1, 3.2

11.1 The “at least one” trick

Example 42 (Independence, and the “at least one” trick). Suppose we roll a 6-sided dice three times. What’s the probability that we get at least one 6?

Solution: The key idea is the following

$$\mathbb{P}[\text{at least one six is rolled}] = 1 - \mathbb{P}[\text{no sixes are rolled}]$$

To put this idea into practice, let $A_1 = [\text{the first dice roll is a 6}]$, $A_2 = [\text{the second dice roll is a 6}]$, and $A_3 = [\text{the third dice roll is a 6}]$. Clearly, A_1, A_2, A_3 are independent because the dice rolls don’t influence each other. Then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{P}[\text{at least one six is rolled}] &= \mathbb{P}[A_1 \cup A_2 \cup A_3] \\ &= 1 - \mathbb{P}[A_1^c \cap A_2^c \cap A_3^c] && \text{by de Morgan’s law} \\ &= 1 - \mathbb{P}[A_1^c] \mathbb{P}[A_2^c] \mathbb{P}[A_3^c] && \text{by independence} \\ &= 1 - \left(\frac{5}{6}\right) \left(\frac{5}{6}\right) \left(\frac{5}{6}\right) \\ &= 1 - \left(\frac{5}{6}\right)^3. \end{aligned}$$

End of Example 42. $\square$

11.2 Discrete Random Variables

Based on sections 3.1 and 3.2 of the textbook

We often associate numbers with outcomes of an experiment.

Definition 43 (Random variables). Let S be a sample space of an experiment. A **random variable** is any rule that associates a number with each outcome in S . In other words, it is a function whose domain is S and whose range is $\mathbb{R}$.

The value of a random variable is thought of as varying depending on the outcome of the experiment. Random variables are usually denoted with capital letters, like X, Y, Z .

Example 44. Roll a 4-sided dice twice (this is the **experiment**). There are 16 possible **outcomes**. The **sample space** is

$$S = \{(x, y) : x, y \in \{1, 2, 3, 4\}\}.$$

Let X be the sum of the two rolls. We can represent X by the following table:

		Dice 2			
		1	2	3	4
Dice 1	1	2	3	4	5
	2	3	4	5	6
	3	4	5	6	7
	4	5	6	7	8

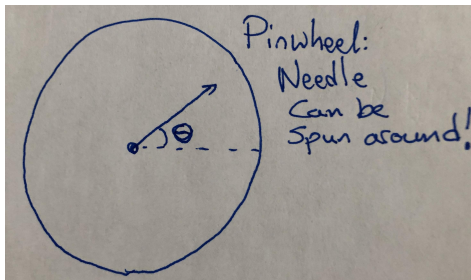
End of Example 44. $\square$

Definition 45 (Discrete random variable). We say that a random variable X is a **discrete random variable** if it can assume only a finite or countably infinite number of distinct values.

Definition 46 (Continuous random variable). A random variable X is said to be **continuous** if

- (i) it takes values in an interval $I \subseteq \mathbb{R}$ or a union of such intervals; and,
- (ii) $\mathbb{P}[X = x] = 0$ for all x .

Example 47 (Pinwheel). Suppose you have a pinwheel as follows.



Suppose we spin the needle. When the needle stops spinning, we measure its angle from the dotted line. Let X be the angle of the needle. So X is a random variable. If X is measured in degrees, then

$$X \in [0, 360)$$

but X could take *any* value between 0 and 360, not just integer values. We have no reason to believe any one angle is more likely than any others – for our idealized pinwheel, all values between 0 and 2π should all be equally likely.

I claim that it must be the case that

$$\Pr[X = x] = 0, \quad \text{for all } x \in [0, 360).$$

We'll prove this by contradiction:

Suppose on the contrary that $\Pr[X = x] = c > 0$ for all x . Let N be any positive integer greater than $1/c$. Let A be a set of any N numbers between 0 and 360. Then using **A.3**

$$\begin{aligned} \Pr[X \in A] &= \sum_{a \in A} \Pr[X = a] \\ &= \sum_{a \in A} c \\ &= c|A| \\ &= cN \\ &> 1. \end{aligned}$$

But this contradicts (vi.). Thus we must have $c = 0$.

End of Example 47. $\square$

Definition 48 (Continuous random variable). We

Example 49 (Bernoulli random variable). Let $p \in (0, 1)$. We say that X is a **Bernoulli random variable** with success parameter p and write $X \sim \text{Bern}(p)$, if

$$X = \begin{cases} 1 & : \text{ with probability } p \\ 0 & : \text{ with probability } 1 - p \end{cases}$$

Conceptually, a Bernoulli random variable represents the flip of a biased coin that has probability p of landing on heads.

End of Example 49. $\square$

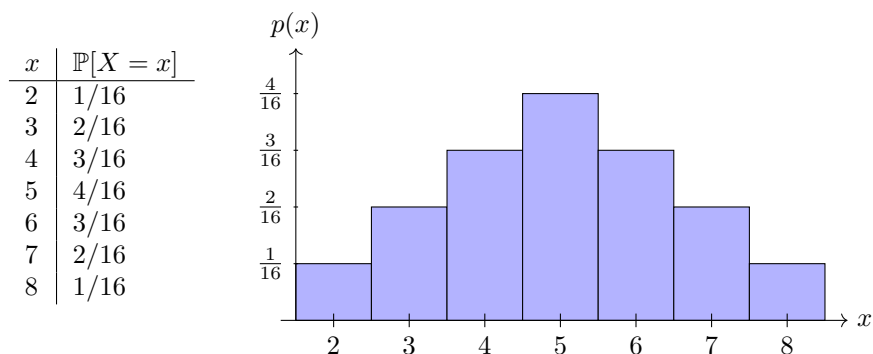
Definition 50 (Probability mass function (pmf)). Let X be a discrete random variable. The **probability mass function** (or **pmf**) of X is the function

$$p(x) = \mathbb{P}[X = x], \quad x \in \mathbb{R}.$$

Example 51. The pmf of X in Example 44 is

$$p(2) = 1/16, \quad p(3) = 2/16, \quad p(4) = 3/16, \quad p(5) = 4/16, \quad p(6) = 3/16, \quad p(7) = 2/16, \quad p(8) = 1/16$$

and $p(x) = 0$ for all other $x \in \mathbb{R}$. It is often useful to write these as a table, and visualize the distribution of X as a histogram:



End of Example 51. $\square$

Definition 52 (Cumulative distribution function (cdf)). Let X be any random variable. The **cumulative distribution function** (or **cdf**) of X is the function

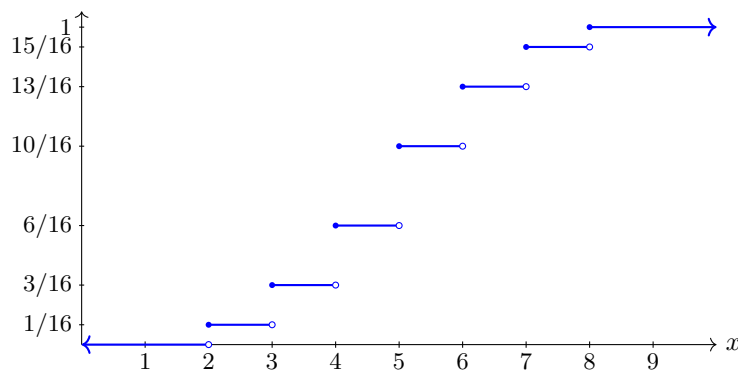
$$F(x) = \mathbb{P}[X \leq x],$$

defined for all $x \in \mathbb{R}$.

Example 53. For the random variable in Example 44, the cdf is given by the following table

x	$F(x) = \mathbb{P}[X \leq x]$
2	1/16
3	3/16
4	6/16
5	10/16
6	13/16
7	15/16
8	1

Here is a plot of $F(x)$. It is the step function shown in blue:



For discrete random variables, the graph of a cdf will always look similar to the above: it will be an increasing step function with open circles on the right endpoints and filled-in circles on the left endpoints.

End of Example 53. $\square$

12 2026-09-21 | Week 05 | Lecture 12

The topic for this lecture: expected value
Reading assignment: Chapter 3.3

Definition 54 (Expected value - discrete random-variable). For a discrete random variable X , the **expected value** of X , denoted $\mathbb{E}[X]$, is

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \sum_x x \mathbb{P}[X = x] \quad (5)$$

where the sum ranges over all distinct values that X can take. (Technical note: the sum on the right hand side of may be an infinite series, which may or may not converge. If the sum on the right-hand side of Eq. (5) does not converge absolutely, then we say that the expected value of X **does not exist**.)

Remark 55. $\mathbb{E}[X]$ is the long-run average of X , if we were to repeat the experiment many times.

The following is a simple but important fact:

Theorem 56 (Linearity of Expectation). *Let a, b be numbers and X and Y be a random variables. Then*

$$\mathbb{E}[aX + b] = a\mathbb{E}[X] + b$$

and

$$\mathbb{E}[aX + bY] = a\mathbb{E}[X] + b\mathbb{E}[Y]. \quad (6)$$

Corollary 57 (Linearity of expectation). *If X and Y are any random variables, then*

$$\mathbb{E}[X + Y] = \mathbb{E}[X] + \mathbb{E}[Y].$$

Proof. Take $a = b = 1$ in Eq. (6). □

Example 58 (Powerball Lottery). The a ticket for the powerball lottery costs \$2. There are two outcomes:

- You win \$300,000,000.
- You don't win any money.

Assume that

$$\mathbb{P}[\text{win}] = \frac{1}{300,000,000}, \quad \mathbb{P}[\text{lose}] = \frac{299,999,999}{300,000,000}.$$

Let X be the net payoff from the game, in dollars. Then, since you had to pay \$2 to buy the ticket,

$$X = \begin{cases} 299,999,998 & : \text{ if you win} \\ -2 & : \text{ if you lose} \end{cases}$$

What is the expected value of X ? By Definition 54,

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[X] &= (299,999,998)\mathbb{P}[\text{win}] + (-2)\mathbb{P}[\text{lose}] \\ &= (299,999,998) \left(\frac{1}{300,000,000} \right) + (-2) \left(\frac{299,999,999}{300,000,000} \right) \\ &= -1. \end{aligned}$$

Conclusion: you “expect” to lose \$1 every time you play. Similarly, if you play twice, you expect to lose \$2. If you play 10 times, you expect to lose \$10. Etc. This is linearity of expectation.

End of Example 58. □

Example 59 (Binomial random variable). Suppose we flip a coin n times. Assume that for each flip, the coin has probability of heads p and probability of tails $1 - p$, where $p \in (0, 1)$.

Let

$$X = (\# \text{ of heads in } n \text{ coin flips})$$

Constructed in this way, the random variable X is a **binomial** random variable with n trials and probability of success p , and we write $X \sim \text{Bin}(n, p)$.

What is $\mathbb{E}[X]$?

Solution: For each $k \in \{1, 2, \dots, n\}$ define

$$Y_k = \begin{cases} 1 & : \text{ } k^{\text{th}} \text{ coin flip is heads} \\ 0 & : \text{ otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Then the key observation is that

$$X = Y_1 + \dots + Y_n.$$

Therefore by linearity of expectation,

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = \mathbb{E}[Y_1] + \dots + \mathbb{E}[Y_n]. \quad (7)$$

Now, what is $\mathbb{E}[Y_k]$? Observe that for each $k = 1, \dots, n$ we have

$$Y_k = \begin{cases} 1 & : \text{ with probability } p \\ 0 & : \text{ with probability } 1 - p. \end{cases}$$

Therefore by Definition 54,

$$\mathbb{E}[Y_k] = (1)(p) + (0)(1 - p) = p$$

for every $k \in \{1, \dots, n\}$. Plugging this into Eq. (7) implies

$$\mathbb{E}[X] = np.$$

End of Example 59. $\square$